

Canada, the United States, Mexico, and the Caribbean

Lesson 3.06.01 | Unit 6: North America and the Caribbean

A NEW GALLERY OPENS

The North America & Caribbean Gallery

A new door has opened at the end of the World Map Hall. Inside, four country labels are laid out on a long table — but none of them are on the wall map yet.

CURATOR'S QUESTION

Where in the world are Canada, the United States, Mexico, and the Caribbean — and how do they fit together as one region?

VIRTUE SPOTLIGHT

Courtesy

Curators study other people's places. When we name countries, we take care to spell them right and say them carefully.

Courtesy means treating every place we study — and the people who live there — with respect.

Your Role: You are a Regional Curator — your job is to help visitors zoom in from the whole world to one region.

NOTICE

What Is a Region?

The world is huge. To study it, geographers look at one region at a time.

A region is a group of places that have something in common — they are close together, share borders, or are connected by oceans, history, or culture.

Today's region has four parts:

Canada, the United States, Mexico, and the Caribbean.

*Simple map showing the four parts of the region
Canada*

SOCRATIC QUESTIONS

- *What do you think these four places have in common?*
- *Can you guess which one is the biggest? The smallest?*
- *Why might it be easier to study a region than the whole world at once?*

NAME

Canada

- Sits in the far north of the region
- Reaches all the way to the Arctic
- Second-largest country on Earth by land area
- **Capital: Ottawa**

Map of North America with Canada
United States

CHAT FRAME

"Point to where Canada is on the map."

"What direction is Canada from where we live?"

"What ocean is north of Canada?"

NAME

The United States

- Sits in the middle of the region
- Shares a long border with Canada to the north
- Shares a long border with Mexico to the south
- Stretches from the Atlantic Ocean to the Pacific Ocean
- **Capital: Washington, D.C.**

Map of North America with the
border between Canada and the United States highlighted

CHAT FRAME

"Which two countries are the United States' neighbors?"

"Which ocean is on the east coast? Which is on the west?"

"Why do we say the United States is 'in the middle'?"

NAME

Mexico

- Sits south of the United States
- Land narrows the further south you go
- Connects North America to Central America
- Touches the Pacific Ocean and the Gulf of Mexico
- **Capital: Mexico City**

Map of North America with Mexico
US, narrow

SOCRATIC QUESTIONS

- What direction is Mexico from the United States?
- What does it mean that Mexico 'connects North America to Central America'?
- Can you trace the shape of Mexico with your finger — how does it change?

NAME

The Caribbean

- Not one country — a group of islands in a warm sea
- East and south of Mexico
- Includes Cuba, Jamaica, Haiti, the Dominican Republic, and Puerto Rico
- **More than 7,000 islands, islets, reefs, and cays!**

Map zoomed into the Caribbean
Haiti/Dominican Republic

CHAT FRAME

"How is the Caribbean different from the other three places?"

"Why is it called a 'group of islands' instead of a country?"

"Can you name one island in the Caribbean?"

Political Map of North America & the Caribbean

INSERT IMAGE

*Political map of North America and the Caribbean — Canada, US, Mexico, and major Caribbean islands labeled with borders.
Source: CIA World Factbook or Library of Congress (public domain)*

NOTICE | NAME | NARRATE

What do I see? Find Canada, the US, Mexico, and the Caribbean. Which is made of islands? **What does it mean?** Then trace the US-Mexico border. Which countries do we study these four places together as one?

PAUSE & THINK

Why Group Them Together?

*The Caribbean is mostly water and islands, while Canada is one huge country. Why might curators still group them together?
United States and Mexico?*

TURN & TALK — Share your thinking with a partner for 30 seconds.

KEY IDEA

A region is not about being the same size or the same shape. These four places sit close together in the same part of the world — they are neighbors.

DISCOVERY FACT + THEN & NOW

DISCOVERY FACT

The Caribbean Sea has more than 7,000 islands, islets, reefs, and cays. Only about 13 of them are independent countries — the rest are smaller territories or uninhabited.

THEN & NOW

In the past, Mexico once reached much farther north than it does today. The border has been the same for a long time.

What stayed the same? People still live close together in many places today.

OPTI SAYS...

When someone says "America," they usually mean the United States — but the word "America" actually covers everything from Canada down to South America. That's why careful people specify "North America" or "South America."

Four Places, One Region

EXHIBIT LABEL

North America and the Caribbean is one region with four major parts: Canada in the north, the United States in the middle, Mexico to the south, and the Caribbean to the east. They are studied together because they share the same part of the world.

SOCRATIC QUESTIONS

- *Can you say where each of the four places sits using only direction words?*
- *If a visitor asked why these four are grouped together, what would you tell them?*
- *What is ONE thing these four places share in common?*

Catch the Mistake!

A student wrote this label for the gallery. Can you spot the errors?

"Mexico is north of the United States. The Caribbean is one big country. Canada is the smallest country in this region."

THREE ERRORS TO FIX

- Mexico is SOUTH of the United States, not north.
- The Caribbean is NOT one country — it is a group of islands.
- Canada is the SECOND LARGEST country on Earth, not the smallest.

Where is Canada compared to the United States, and where is Mexico compared to the United States? Use direction words like north and

SCAFFOLD: DIRECTION-WORD SENTENCE FRAME

Canada is _____ of the United States.

Mexico is _____ of the United States.

I know this because _____.

Hint: Use the map source! Trace the borders with your finger.

What makes the Caribbean different from the other three places in this region? Give one piece of evidence from the lesson.

SCAFFOLD: COMPARE & CONTRAST

CANADA, US, MEXICO

Each is ONE country
Large, connected landmasses
Have borders you can trace

THE CARIBBEAN

NOT one country — many islands
Mostly water and scattered islands
7,000+ islands, only ~13 are countries

Gallery Welcome Label

Write the welcome label visitors read when they step into the new gallery. In 3-4 sentences, name all four places (Canada, the United States, Mexico, and the Caribbean), tell where one reason why curators study them together.

YOUR LABEL MUST ANSWER:

- What four places are in this gallery?
- Where is each one? (Use direction words!)
- Why are they grouped as one region?

Capture Today's Learning

Finish this sentence in your own words:

In this exhibit, I learned that ____ because ____.

CHAT FRAME

"What is the ONE biggest thing you learned today?"

"How do you know it is true? What is your evidence?"

"Say it out loud before you write it down."

SELF-CHECK

Test Your Memory

1. Which country sits in the middle, between Canada and Mexico?

A) Cuba B) The United States C) Canada

Answer: B

2. Which of these is part of the Caribbean?

A) Mexico City B) Ottawa C) Cuba

Answer: C

3. Why do curators study these four places as one region?

Complete on Your Lesson Page

EVIDENCE QUESTIONS

1. Where is Canada compared to the United States, and where is Mexico compared to the United States? Use direction words like north and south. 2. What makes the Caribbean different from the other three places in this region? Give one piece of evidence from the lesson.

CURATOR TASK

Gallery Welcome Label

Write 3-4 sentences: name all four places, tell where each site is located, and why the sites are studied together.

GREAT WORK, REGIONAL CURATOR!

You placed the labels.

You placed Canada, the United States, Mexico, and the Caribbean on the map and wrote the gallery's welcome label. Visitors will know exactly what part of the world this gallery is about.

COMING NEXT

Next time, the country labels stay up — but a brand-new set of labels arrives. These ones name mountains, rivers, and plains. We're going to start